

One-Page Trade-Off Brief Template

Day 3 · Activity 3 handout. Translate one technical trade-off into a brief a non-technical stakeholder can act on. The discipline: the **whole brief fits on one page**; the appendix is references, not body. This becomes SEP §3.

The translation discipline

Translating technical to business is not "use simpler words." It is **re-framing**: the same trade-off, expressed in terms the audience already cares about.

TECHNICAL FRAMING	BUSINESS FRAMING
"We chose async write to audit because sync would breach our p95 SLO"	"We chose to ship 50ms faster on the dispatcher screen, accepting that audit logs may lag 10 seconds — relevant to compliance Q3 review timing"
"We accepted a denormalized ticket_ids array in ReconcileEvent"	"We're optimizing reconcile reads at the cost of a future query type. We'd revisit if that query becomes hot"
"We're shipping a modular monolith, not a service"	"We're shipping faster by not separating this code; we accept the cost of a future split if traffic grows 5x"

What they need to know vs decide

WHAT THEY NEED TO KNOW	WHAT THEY NEED TO DECIDE
The headline outcome	Whether to approve the choice
The cost we're accepting	Whether the cost is acceptable
The trigger to revisit	Whether the trigger is well-chosen
What we need from them	Whether to provide it

Strip everything else. Detail goes in the appendix or "available on request."

The template

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# Trade-off brief: <short feature name>
**For:** <stakeholder name> | **From:** <triad> | **Date:** <today>

## The decision (1 sentence)
We are choosing [X] over [Y] for the <feature> work, accepting [cost].

## Why this matters to you (1-2 sentences in their currency)
<Cost / customer outcome / regulatory exposure / time>

## The choice
- **What we're doing:** <plain language; 2-3 bullets>
- **What we're explicitly not doing:** <2-3 bullets>
- **The cost we're accepting:** <1 bullet>

## What would change our mind
<Concrete trigger; metric or organizational change>

## What we need from you
☐ Approval to proceed as proposed
☐ Specific concern you want us to address
☐ Information we don't have

## Appendix (linked, not pasted)
- Technical detail in TCD §5 / TMD §X
- Sequence diagram
- SLO budget
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Worked example — async audit write brief for Compliance

Trade-off brief: Reconcile audit write timing

****For:**** Pat Lee, Compliance Owner | ****From:**** Reconcile triad | ****Date:**** 2026-04-29

The decision

We are choosing async audit write (1–10s lag) over synchronous (instant) to keep dispatcher reconcile screens fast.

Why this matters to you

This affects the audit-trail timing your SOC 2 process depends on. Audit events are still durable (Kafka topic + DLQ) – they just appear in the audit store 1–10 seconds after the user action.

The choice

- ****What we're doing:**** Publish audit events to a durable Kafka topic at user-action time; consumer writes to the audit store within 1–10 seconds.
- ****What we're explicitly not doing:**** Synchronous write to the audit store on the user's hot path (would add 30–80ms; breaks our p95 SLO).
- ****The cost we're accepting:**** A regulator querying within 5 seconds of an event sees stale state.

What would change our mind

A regulator or customer contractually requires synchronous audit visibility within < 1 second.

What we need from you

- Approval that the 1–10s lag is acceptable for our SOC 2 process
- Confirmation of acceptable lag bound (we propose $\leq 10s$ p99)
- Note of any contract requiring sync audit (we know of none)

Appendix

- Technical detail: TCD §5 trade-off 2, TMD §4 sequence diagrams
- Latency budget: TCD §4

The bar for "good"

- **Whole brief on one page** — the constraint is forcing.
- **Plain language** in the headline; technical terms only in appendix references.
- **Cost in their currency** — dollars for CFO, customer experience for CS, audit risk for Compliance.
- **Specific ask** at the end — not "thoughts welcome."